

Ask Jamie: Market Value & Compensation

Knowledge File

This knowledge file helps job seekers and employees assess their market value and negotiate compensation. It combines **salary data**, **geographic differences**, **pay-transparency regulations**, **sector-specific pay structures**, **negotiation strategies** and **recent compensation trends**. The focus is on the United States in late 2025; all data and laws cited are current as of **November 2025** (dates in brackets indicate sources).

Salary Range Research by Role & Industry

Market value depends on role, experience, industry, company size and economic conditions. Reliable data sources include the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS), industry salary surveys, and reputable salary platforms. Below are examples of salary ranges for common professional roles.

Software Developers

- **Median salary** – The BLS reports that **software developers** had a median annual wage of **\$133,080** in May 2024. The lowest 10 percent earned **less than \$79,850** and the top 10 percent earned **more than \$211,450** ¹. This median includes developers in multiple industries; software publishers pay higher medians (~\$149,990) while computer systems design firms pay lower medians (~\$129,890) ².
- **Experience and seniority** – entry-level developers with fewer than three years' experience typically start near the lower end of the range (≈\$80k), mid-level developers may earn between **\$130k–\$180k**, and senior developers and engineering managers often exceed **\$200k**, especially at large technology firms or in high-cost areas.

Data Scientists

- **Median salary** – According to BLS data summarised by Coursera, the **median annual salary for data scientists** was **\$112,590** in May 2024 ³. Salary aggregation sites show higher averages because they include bonuses and equity; for example, Glassdoor lists a combined figure of **\$152k**, while Indeed reports **\$129k** ⁴.
- **Experience levels** – Glassdoor's 2025 data shows total compensation (salary + bonus) rising from about **\$133k** for data scientists with 0–1 years of experience to **\$234k** for those with 15+ years ⁵. Advanced degrees can boost pay; Zippia notes that data scientists with master's degrees earn roughly **\$109k** on average versus **\$101k** with a bachelor's degree ⁶.
- **Industry differences** – Data scientists in industries such as **consumer services, arts, agriculture and information technology** enjoy higher total pay (around **\$144k–\$154k**) ⁷.

Marketing Managers

- **Median salary** – The BLS lists the **median annual salary for marketing managers** as **\$161,030** with a median hourly wage of **\$77** ⁸ . Percentiles show the bottom 10 percent at about **\$81,900** and the 75th percentile around **\$211,080** ⁹ .
- **State variation** – Salary levels vary substantially by state. For example, 2024 BLS data shows median pay of **\$178,160** in California and **\$140,620** in Texas ¹⁰ . High-paying metropolitan areas include the San Jose–Sunnyvale–Santa Clara region (**\$228,580**) and San Francisco–Oakland–Fremont (**\$212,520**) ¹¹ .

Lessons for Researching Salary Ranges

1. **Use multiple sources** – Compare BLS data with salary surveys (Glassdoor, LinkedIn, Payscale) and industry reports to triangulate a realistic range. Salary platforms may include bonuses and equity; always check whether figures represent base pay or total compensation.
2. **Adjust for seniority** – Junior roles generally start near the 10th–25th percentile, mid-level professionals hover around the median, and senior or specialized roles approach the 75th percentile or above. Certifications and graduate degrees can raise earnings.
3. **Consider industry profitability** – Sectors like technology, finance and pharmaceuticals typically pay higher wages than education or non-profit sectors. Look for industry-specific salary surveys for more precise benchmarks.

Geographic Salary Variance

Compensation differs across regions due to cost of living, local demand for skills, and state tax policies. Relocating or working remotely can therefore increase or decrease real earnings.

Cost-of-Living Differences

- **San Francisco vs. Dallas** – Expatistan's November 15 2025 data shows that **San Francisco's cost of living is roughly 41 percent higher than Dallas** ¹² . Housing in San Francisco is **86 percent more expensive** ¹³ , while food costs about **44 percent more** ¹⁴ and transportation about **11 percent more** ¹⁵ . Rent for a two-bedroom apartment in San Francisco can exceed **\$4,800 per month**, compared with around **\$2,400** in Dallas ¹⁶ .
- **Regional pay differences** – Because living costs vary, employers in high-cost cities often pay higher salaries. For example, software engineers in San Francisco or New York can earn 30–40 percent more than in mid-size markets like Dallas or Austin. However, remote work is eroding geographic pay premiums; some companies adopt location-agnostic pay bands or adjust pay downward when employees move to cheaper areas.

Locality and Government Pay

- **Federal GS system** – U.S. federal employees are paid according to the **General Schedule (GS)**, which has 15 grades and 10 steps. The 2025 GS base pay table shows annual salaries ranging from **\$22,360** (Grade 1 Step 1) to **\$162,672** (Grade 15 Step 10) ¹⁷ . Locality pay adjustments increase these numbers based on the metro area; for example, the San Francisco locality adds about 45 percent.

- **State taxes** – Workers in states with high income taxes (e.g., California, New York) may keep less take-home pay than those in tax-friendly states like Texas or Florida. When comparing offers, calculate net pay after federal, state and local taxes.

Research Strategies

1. **Use cost-of-living calculators** – Tools like the Council for Community and Economic Research's **Cost of Living Index** and Expatistan's comparison site provide city-to-city cost differences. Note that price data may be crowd-sourced; treat them as approximations.
2. **Adjust salary expectations** – If relocating from a high-cost to a lower-cost area, expect employers to offer lower salaries. In remote roles, some firms pay the same regardless of location, while others tie pay to geographic bands.
3. **Consider purchasing power** – A \$120k salary in Dallas may provide a higher standard of living than \$150k in San Francisco once housing and taxes are factored in.

Pay Transparency Laws & Best Practices

Pay-transparency regulations require employers to disclose salary ranges in job postings or upon request. Knowing the law in your state can strengthen negotiation leverage.

State-Specific Transparency Laws

- **California** – Effective **Jan 1 2023**, employers must disclose the salary range in all job postings, may not ask applicants about pay history, and must provide pay ranges to current employees upon request ¹⁸. The law applies to any employer with at least one employee, including remote jobs that could be performed in California ¹⁹. Penalties range from **\$100 to \$10,000 per violation** ²⁰.
- **Colorado** – Under the **Equal Pay for Equal Work Act**, updated in **2024**, employers must include pay scales, job descriptions, benefits and the expected closing date in all job postings ²¹. This applies to any job that could be performed in Colorado (except roles entirely outside the state) and covers employers with at least one worker ²². Fines range from **\$500 to \$10,000 per violation** ²³.
- **Illinois** – Beginning **Jan 1 2025**, job postings must include the wage scale and a general description of benefits ²⁴. The law applies to employers with 15+ employees, including remote roles tied to Illinois ²⁵; violations can incur fines of **\$500–\$10,000** ²⁴.
- **New York** – Since **Sept 17 2023**, employers with four or more employees must list salary ranges in postings for jobs that can be performed in New York or report to a New York supervisor ²⁶. Fines increase from **\$1,000** for a first violation to **\$3,000** for subsequent violations ²⁷.
- **Washington** – Effective **Jan 1 2023**, all job postings must include salary ranges and a general description of benefits ²⁸. The law applies to employers with **15 or more employees**, including those outside Washington recruiting Washington-based workers ²⁹. Violations may result in damages plus fines up to **\$500 for a first offense** and **\$1,000 or 10 percent of damages** for repeats ³⁰.

Other states such as Connecticut, Hawaii, Maryland, Nevada and Rhode Island have varying requirements; some require disclosure upon an applicant's request or after an interview ³¹. Many states also prohibit employers from asking about salary history.

Best Practices for Navigating Transparency

1. **Know your state's law** – If you live in or apply for jobs in states with pay-transparency requirements, you can cite the law and request the salary range early in the process.
2. **Request ranges for remote roles** – Even when employers do not list ranges, some states require disclosure upon request. Politely ask for the pay range before discussing your current salary.
3. **Use disclosed ranges strategically** – When a range is wide, aim for the higher end by emphasizing your experience and skills. If the listed range is below market, use external data to justify a higher expectation.

Union vs. Government vs. Private Sector Compensation

Unionized Compensation

Unions negotiate wages, benefits and working conditions collectively, leading to standardized pay and improved benefits.

- **Wage premium** – The Laborers' International Union of North America (LIUNA) notes that union members earn higher pay: the **average hourly wage for union workers is \$33.86** versus **\$28.95** for non-union workers ³². Median weekly pay is **\$1,337** for union workers compared with **\$1,138** for non-union workers ³³ —a pay advantage of over **15 percent**.
- **Benefits** – Union employees receive benefits valued at **\$22.26 per hour**, versus **\$11.32** for non-union workers ³⁴. Defined-benefit pensions cover **79 percent** of union workers but only **17 percent** of non-union workers ³⁵. About **96 percent** of union workers have employer-provided health insurance vs. **69 percent** of non-union workers ³⁶.
- **Negotiation process** – Wages and benefits are set through collective bargaining agreements covering all employees in the bargaining unit. Raises follow negotiated schedules (e.g., annual step increases). Individual negotiation is rare.

Government Pay Structures

- **General Schedule (GS)** – Most U.S. federal civilian employees are paid under the GS system, with 15 grades and 10 steps. Base pay ranges from **\$22,360** at GS-1 Step 1 to **\$162,672** at GS-15 Step 10 ¹⁷, with locality adjustments up to ~50 percent in high-cost areas. Employees automatically advance steps over time (typically every 1–3 years), and promotions to higher grades require competition or additional responsibilities.
- **Benefits and job security** – Government roles often include defined-benefit pensions (e.g., Federal Employees Retirement System), subsidized health insurance, and generous leave policies. Job security is higher due to civil-service protections but salary growth may be slower than in the private sector.

Private Sector (Non-Union) Compensation

Private employers have more discretion in setting pay and often use **pay bands** with broad ranges. Compensation packages may include base salary, annual bonus, stock options, commissions, and other incentives. Larger companies typically offer robust benefits (health insurance, 401(k) with match, equity awards), while smaller firms may offer fewer perks. Negotiation is usually individual; high performers may negotiate signing bonuses or equity grants.

Key Differences

Dimension	Unionized Jobs	Government (GS) Jobs	Private Sector Jobs
Pay determination	Set by collective bargaining agreements; standardized increases	Determined by GS grade/step tables and locality; step increases are automatic	Determined by employer; ranges vary by company, industry and role
Ability to negotiate	Limited; individuals rarely negotiate pay outside union contract	Limited; negotiation may occur when first accepting the position or for higher grades	High; candidates negotiate salary, bonuses, equity and benefits
Benefits	Generous health insurance, pensions, training funds ³⁷	Defined-benefit pensions, stable health plans, paid leave	Vary widely; some companies offer comprehensive packages, others minimal
Job security	High; seniority and contract terms protect against layoffs	High; civil-service rules make termination difficult	Variable; employment at will in most states
Pay growth	Predictable; step or percentage increases per contract	Predictable within grades; limited leaps between grades	Potentially high; merit-based raises, promotions, bonuses and equity growth

Negotiation Strategies & Historical Context

Guidelines for Negotiating Salary

1. **Research market value** – Use multiple data sources (BLS, salary surveys, job postings) to determine the range for your role, industry and location. For remote jobs, consider both high- and low-cost regions; remote employers may base pay on candidate location or adopt a single global band.
2. **Understand total compensation** – Assess base pay plus bonuses, stock options, health insurance, retirement contributions, paid leave and other perks. In union and government roles, benefits can account for a significant portion of total compensation ³⁷.
3. **Know your priorities** – Decide what matters most (e.g., salary, work-life balance, flexibility, growth opportunities). When negotiating, emphasize the aspects that align with your priorities.
4. **Anchor high but reasonable** – Aim for the upper end of the range based on your experience and market research. Provide evidence (salary reports, your achievements) to justify the request.
5. **Leverage pay-transparency laws** – In states with disclosure requirements, ask for the salary range early in the process. If the posted range is wide, clarify the factors that determine placement within the range.
6. **Consider cost-of-living and remote work** – For remote roles, some employers adjust pay based on location. Location-based adjustment is common—**63 percent** of remote employees receive such

adjustments ³⁸ , and **40 percent** of employers say geography affects offers ³⁹ . Decide whether you accept a lower nominal salary in exchange for living in a cheaper area.

7. **Document your achievements** – Prepare a dossier of accomplishments, certifications and metrics that demonstrate value. Use this to negotiate raises or promotions.
8. **Practice and be patient** – Rehearse your negotiation conversation, remain professional and be prepared for counter-offers. If a satisfactory offer is not possible, be ready to walk away.

Historical & Future Trends

- **Remote work and salary benchmarks** – Surveys show that **98 percent** of remote workers wish to continue remote work ⁴⁰ , prompting companies to rethink salary benchmarks. Employers such as GitLab and Remote.com are adopting **global pay bands** ⁴¹ . At the same time, **54 percent** of workers would leave for flexible work options ⁴² , and **75 percent** are willing to accept reduced pay for remote work ⁴³ .
- **Location-based adjustments** – Remote work has led to debates over whether employees should be paid based on company headquarters, employee residence or a global standard. **63 percent** of remote employees receive location-based salary adjustments ³⁸ , and **72 percent** of employers are reconsidering pay structures to reflect remote work dynamics ⁴⁴ .
- **Inflation and raises** – After rapid wage growth in 2022–2023, salary increase budgets are stabilizing. Consulting firm WTW predicts average U.S. salary increases of about **3.7 percent in 2025** (compared with 3.8 percent in 2024). Real wage growth depends on inflation; employees may need to negotiate cost-of-living adjustments to maintain purchasing power.
- **Pay equity and transparency** – The expansion of pay-transparency laws and corporate commitments to diversity, equity and inclusion (DEI) are reshaping compensation practices. Applicants increasingly expect to see pay ranges in job postings and to avoid salary history questions. States that do not yet have transparency laws are considering legislation ⁴⁵ .
- **Benefits trends** – Wellness programs, mental-health benefits, flexible schedules and remote-work stipends are gaining importance. Employers may use these perks to differentiate offers, especially when salary budgets are tight.

Conclusion

Determining your market value requires **rigorous research**, an understanding of **geographic and industry variations**, knowledge of **legal requirements**, and a clear sense of your priorities. Salaries vary widely by role and location: for example, software developers earn a median of **\$133k** ¹ , data scientists around **\$113k** ³ , and marketing managers about **\$161k** ⁸ . Cost-of-living differences can make a \$120k salary in Dallas equivalent to a \$160k salary in San Francisco ⁴⁶ , while new pay-transparency laws in states like California, Colorado and New York empower candidates with more information ²⁰ . Union and government roles offer predictable pay and strong benefits ⁴⁷ ¹⁷ , whereas private sector jobs provide greater negotiation flexibility and potential upside. By combining data, legal awareness and negotiation skills, you can approach job offers and raises with confidence and advocate for compensation that reflects your true market value.

¹ ² Software Developers, Quality Assurance Analysts, and Testers : Occupational Outlook Handbook: : U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/computer-and-information-technology/software-developers.htm>

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